

ShiftSure Case Study: Applying Ice House Entrepreneurship Principles

Jordan Ellis's journey with ShiftSure exemplifies the Ice House Entrepreneurship principles in action. From identifying a systemic market failure in frontline staffing to building a reliability-driven platform that has generated over \$400,000 in revenue and completed 4,000+ shifts, Ellis demonstrated how entrepreneurial thinking transforms challenges into opportunities. This exercise explores how Ellis applied the eight Ice House principles and guides you to apply these same lessons to your own entrepreneurial journey.



The Challenge

Understanding how proven entrepreneurial principles drive real-world success



The Approach

Analyze Ellis's decisions through the Ice House framework



Your Application

Apply these principles to your own business challenges



How Jordan Ellis Applied the 8 Ice House Principles

The Ice House Entrepreneurship program teaches eight fundamental principles that guide successful entrepreneurs. Jordan Ellis's creation and growth of ShiftSure provides a masterclass in applying these principles to solve real-world problems. Let's examine how Ellis embodied each principle throughout ShiftSure's journey from concept to a thriving platform serving 40+ QSR locations across four metropolitan areas.

1

Ideas Come from Opportunities

Ellis's Application: Rather than starting with technology, Ellis identified the opportunity through conversations with franchise owners, restaurant managers, and frontline employees. He recognized that staffing unreliability had become existential for operators—a massive pain point in a \$150 billion market. The idea emerged from observing a genuine market failure, not from a boardroom brainstorm.

2

Opportunities Exist in Problems

Ellis's Application: Ellis saw that QSR managers faced a fundamental question daily: "Who will actually show up today?" With turnover exceeding 150% annually and billions lost to understaffing, the problem was clear. Instead of accepting this as inevitable, Ellis recognized it as an opportunity to create a reliability-driven marketplace that could transform how frontline staffing operates.

3

Action is the Foundation of Success

Ellis's Application: Ellis didn't wait for perfect conditions. He launched pilots across four metropolitan areas, tested the SureScore™ algorithm with real workers and real shifts, and iterated based on actual performance data. By completing over 4,000 shifts, he proved the concept through action rather than endless planning.

4

Knowledge Comes from Learning

Ellis's Application: Despite his technology background, Ellis recognized he needed to learn from the frontline. He built a diverse founding team including Priya Nandakumar (CTO with fintech experience) and Darnell Whitfield (workforce development expert). Each completed shift generated data that improved the SureScore model, creating a compounding learning advantage.

5

Wealth Comes in Many Forms

Ellis's Application: Ellis defined success beyond revenue. ShiftSure's mission—"to make reliability visible, measurable, and economically valuable in frontline work"—creates value for workers (better opportunities), operators (reduced stress), and society (career mobility). The long-term vision of building a "Reliability Economy" demonstrates wealth creation across multiple dimensions.

6

Wealth is Created, Not Taken

Ellis's Application: Rather than simply redistributing existing staffing dollars, ShiftSure created new value. By reducing no-shows, improving coverage, and lowering manager burnout, the platform generated savings and efficiency gains that didn't exist before. The SureScore system created a new asset—portable reliability credentials—that benefits workers throughout their careers.

7

Successful People Work for Themselves

Ellis's Application: Ellis left his corporate technology career to pursue his vision. More importantly, ShiftSure empowers frontline workers to work for themselves by building portable reliability scores that unlock better opportunities. Workers with higher SureScores gain access to premium shifts, faster pay, and additional benefits—controlling their own economic destiny.

8

Successful People Share Their Wealth

Ellis's Application: The inclusion of Darnell Whitfield as Head of Workforce Development signals commitment to career mobility and community impact. ShiftSure's vision extends beyond profit to transforming reliability into a credential that follows workers throughout their careers, creating pathways out of precarious employment for thousands of frontline workers.

Your Turn: Apply the Ice House Principles to Your Business

Now it's time to reflect on your own entrepreneurial journey. Use the eight Ice House principles that guided Jordan Ellis to analyze your current business challenges and identify new opportunities. This exercise will help you think like an entrepreneur, recognize opportunities in problems, and develop actionable strategies for growth. Be honest and specific in your responses—the more detailed your reflection, the more valuable your insights will be.

01

Ideas Come from Opportunities

Reflection Question: What opportunities have you observed in your market or community? Where are customers struggling with problems that current solutions don't adequately address? How did you identify your business idea—was it from personal experience, customer conversations, or market observation?

03

Action is the Foundation of Success

Reflection Question: What concrete actions have you taken to test your business idea? Have you launched a pilot, conducted customer interviews, or built a minimum viable product? What's one action you could take this week to move your business forward? What's holding you back from taking action?

05

Wealth Comes in Many Forms

Reflection Question: Beyond financial returns, what other forms of value does your business create? How does your work impact your customers' lives, your community, or your own personal growth? What does success look like across multiple dimensions (impact, relationships, learning, fulfillment)?

07

Successful People Work for Themselves

Reflection Question: How does your business give you control over your economic destiny? Does your business model empower your customers or employees to have more control over their lives? What autonomy and ownership are you building into your business structure?

02

Opportunities Exist in Problems

Reflection Question: What specific problems does your business solve? How significant is the pain point for your customers? Can you quantify the cost of the problem (in time, money, or frustration)? Are there additional problems in your industry that represent untapped opportunities?

04

Knowledge Comes from Learning

Reflection Question: What have you learned from your customers, competitors, or early experiments? Who could you learn from (mentors, team members, industry experts)? What data are you collecting to improve your product or service? How are you systematically capturing and applying lessons learned?

06

Wealth is Created, Not Taken

Reflection Question: How does your business create new value rather than simply redistributing existing resources? What efficiencies, innovations, or improvements does your solution generate? How can you expand the total value available in your market rather than competing for existing dollars?

08

Successful People Share Their Wealth

Reflection Question: How are you sharing the value your business creates with employees, customers, or your community? What's your plan for giving back as your business grows? How can you build wealth-sharing into your business model from the beginning rather than as an afterthought?

"The Ice House principles aren't just theory—they're a practical framework for building businesses that create lasting value. Jordan Ellis's journey with ShiftSure shows that when you identify real opportunities, take action, learn continuously, and create value for others, success follows naturally."



Next Steps

After completing this reflection, identify your top three insights and one specific action you'll take in the next 7 days to apply an Ice House principle to your business. Share your commitment with a mentor, peer, or accountability partner to increase your likelihood of follow-through.